

From \$200 to Arweave: How a Canadian With a Driver's License and a Phone Got Into Crypto in an Afternoon

A field report from the onboarding trenches — what actually happened, what it actually cost, and where the real liquidity is hiding.

The short version, for the impatient: You can go from a CIBC chequing account to holding a hard-to-find token like Arweave in about an afternoon, for almost no fees, using nothing but a driver's license and a phone. The on-ramp I used was Kraken. If you want to skip straight to it:

Sign-up link: <https://invite.kraken.com/JDNW/7uuhqx1c>

Referral code (tap to copy) — required even with the link, and what enrolled me in the up-to-\$350 bonus that paid me \$45 in BTC:

2twtq8yj

There's a particular kind of paralysis that hits you the first time you try to buy a cryptocurrency that isn't Bitcoin. You know the token you want exists. You can see its chart. But every path to actually owning it seems to run through some sketchy bridge, a decentralized exchange you've never heard of, or a "just send me your seed phrase" Telegram group that smells like a federal indictment.

I wanted Arweave (AR) — the permanent-storage token, the one that underwrites a chunk of the decentralized web. In Canada, getting it cleanly used to feel impossible. So I ran the experiment myself: start with \$200 CAD in a CIBC chequing account, a driver's license, and a smartphone, and see how far that gets me on Kraken.

Here's the honest accounting — and I'm going to walk you through it the way I'd walk a friend through it at the kitchen table, one step at a time, so that by the end you could repeat the whole thing yourself.

The starting line: a license, a phone, and zero patience

Verification was the part I expected to hate. It wasn't.

Think about what most financial institutions demand before they'll let you in: proof of address, a void cheque, sometimes an in-person branch visit. The mental model most people carry into

crypto is that it'll be worse than a bank, not better. So here's the reframe worth absorbing early: a regulated exchange in Canada actually asks for *less* friction than opening certain bank products, because the identity check is built around a single photo ID and a live camera capture rather than a paper trail.

In concrete terms, you need a government-issued photo ID and a camera — that's the whole shopping list. A driver's license (front and back) plus the selfie/confirmation photo your phone takes is enough to reach the verification level that unlocks Canadian-dollar funding, trading, deposits, and withdrawals. No notarized documents, no faxing a utility bill to a P.O. box in 2004. I had my Kraken account verified in minutes, not days.

Now, *why* does it ask for real ID at all? This is worth understanding, because it's the difference between an exchange you can trust and one that disappears with your deposit. Kraken is a registered **Restricted Dealer** in Canada, with the Ontario Securities Commission as its principal regulator and recognition across the provinces under the passport system. It's also a FINTRAC-registered money services business. The ID requirement is a *symptom* of that regulatory posture, not a nuisance bolted on top of it — a fly-by-night operation wouldn't bother. So when you find yourself mildly annoyed at photographing your license, reframe it: that annoyance is the same mechanism keeping the operation honest. (One caveat every Canadian should internalize, because it cuts the other way: crypto held here is **not** CIPF-insured the way your brokerage stocks are. Regulated is not the same as government-backstopped. Hold that thought; we'll return to risk at the end.)

The money in: CIBC → Interac e-Transfer → Kraken, for free

This is where most people brace for the hidden tax. I did too — and understanding *why* I braced is half the lesson.

Every Canadian has been trained by experience to expect a spread somewhere. Your bank's foreign-exchange rate is never the real rate. The ATM that isn't yours charges \$3. So the instinct, when funding a crypto account, is to assume the exchange skims a percentage on the way in and calls it a "processing fee." I logged into CIBC, sent an **Interac e-Transfer** to fund my Kraken account, and waited for the haircut.

There wasn't one.

Per Kraken's own support documentation, deposits via e-Transfer are free, and the withdrawal fee is 10 CAD. Free. Not 1.5%, not 0.5% — both numbers you'll still see quoted in older third-party "reviews" that haven't updated since Kraken made Canadian e-Transfer deposits free in 2025.

This is a small but important media-literacy lesson for crypto generally: the aggregator blogs lag reality by a year or more, because nobody goes back to update an old "fees" post once it's ranking on Google. So trust the official fee page over the review sites, always. My full \$200 landed as \$200.

A couple of specifics matter if you're routing through CIBC the way I was, and they're the kind of thing that trips people up precisely because they're mundane:

The first is that the name has to match. The legal name on your CIBC e-Transfer profile must match your Kraken account name exactly, or the deposit stalls in limbo. This catches people because the e-Transfer "nickname" field is something most of us set once, years ago, and forgot. Two minutes in your banking app to fix it saves you a support ticket and a day of anxiety wondering where your \$200 went.

The second is that the limits are generous enough to be irrelevant for a beginner. Kraken caps e-Transfer at 10,000 CAD per transaction and per day, 30,000 CAD per week, and 100,000 CAD per month. Here's the subtle part worth internalizing: CIBC's *own* personal e-Transfer ceiling — roughly 3,000 CAD daily and 30,000 CAD over 30 days — is actually the tighter constraint. When two systems each impose a limit, the smaller one always wins, so it's your bank, not the exchange, that you'll bump into first. Either way, a \$200 experiment doesn't come close to either.

So the onboarding margin — the thing everyone fears — was *zero percent* on the way in. The only e-Transfer cost you'll ever see is that flat **\$10 CAD** when you eventually pull cash back out.

The other free door: crypto in, crypto out

If you already hold crypto somewhere — another exchange, a hardware wallet, a friend paying you back in ETH — there's a second on-ramp that's just as cheap, and understanding it teaches you something about how exchanges actually make money.

Here's the principle first, then the specifics. **Kraken doesn't add its own fee to most crypto deposits, and it doesn't mark up crypto withdrawals either.** Per Kraken's support pages, most cryptocurrency deposits are free, and on withdrawals the only charge is the **blockchain network fee** required to move the coins on-chain. That distinction — between a fee the exchange invents and a cost the blockchain itself imposes — is one of the most useful mental models in all of crypto. The network fee is like postage: it goes to the people running the network (the miners or validators), not to Kraken. The exchange isn't skimming a margin on top. So when you send AR, ETH, SOL, or BTC *into* Kraken you pay nothing to Kraken to receive it; when you send it back *out*

you pay only what the network itself charges, which on a cheap chain like Solana is literally pennies.

Why does this matter beyond saving a few dollars? Because it tells you the exchange isn't a roach motel — the trap where assets check in but can't check out without an exit tax. Your funds can leave Kraken for self-custody whenever you want, paying only the unavoidable network cost. That freedom-to-leave is, paradoxically, one of the strongest reasons to feel comfortable arriving. (The one rule to respect: every chain has a *minimum* withdrawal amount, so you can't move dust — sweep small balances together first.)

The trade: \$200 in, \$194 of Arweave out

Now the part where fees actually show up — and where the single most valuable lesson in this whole article lives.

I didn't subscribe to anything. No Kraken+, no premium tier. I just used the simple in-app convert to turn my \$200 CAD into AR. When the dust settled, I held **about \$194 worth of Arweave**.

Let's make sure the ~\$6 gap makes sense to you, because if you understand *this* you understand most of what beginners get wrong about crypto costs. The simple one-tap Buy/Convert flow carries roughly a **1% trading fee plus a small spread** baked into the quoted price. On \$200, the 1% is about two dollars; the rest is the spread, which is the small difference between the buy price and the sell price at that instant. Fast, frictionless, and you pay a few dollars for the privilege. Nothing was hidden — it was simply the price of the easy button.

And that phrase, "the easy button," is the key, because here's the thing nobody tells beginners: that 1% convenience fee is **not** the cheapest way to trade on the platform. It's just the most obvious one. Which brings us to the two-doors idea.

The Basic app vs. Kraken Pro: same login, very different prices

Picture one house with two front doors. Same house, same furniture, same locks — but the two doors charge different tolls to walk through. That's the relationship between the basic Kraken app and Kraken Pro, and grasping it is worth real money over time.

The basic Kraken app is the friendly door — buy, sell, convert, track your portfolio. It charges that flat ~1% on instant trades. It's perfect for a first-timer who wants AR in their wallet in thirty

seconds and doesn't want to think about order books.

Kraken Pro is the other door into the *same* account — same custody, same security, same login — but with a real order book and a **maker/taker fee schedule that starts at 0.25% / 0.40%** and *falls* as your volume grows. (A "maker" adds an order to the book and waits; a "taker" grabs an existing order immediately. Makers are rewarded with lower fees because they supply the liquidity everyone else trades against — a small but elegant incentive worth knowing.) For high-volume traders the top tiers approach zero. Pro also gives you limit orders, stop-losses, and trailing stops. You toggle between the two doors freely.

So the lesson, if you trade more than occasionally: do your serious buying on Kraken Pro and pay a quarter-percent instead of a full percent. I deliberately used the basic app for my AR buy because I wanted to *measure* the honest beginner experience — and ~\$194-on-\$200 is exactly that. But now that I understand the two doors, I live on Pro, and you probably will too once the platform stops feeling intimidating.

(There's also a **Kraken+ subscription** at about \$4.99/month that waives the trading fee on convert-style trades up to \$10,000/month of volume. Run the arithmetic before you subscribe: it only pays off if your monthly volume is high enough that the waived fees exceed the \$4.99, and even then spreads still apply and it doesn't cover Pro spot trades. For most people, simply learning Kraken Pro is the better free upgrade.)

One note for the builders in the audience, because this ecosystem rewards the curious: Kraken also exposes a full **API** — REST, WebSocket, and FIX — from the same account, spanning spot and futures. If you want recurring-buy bots, systematic strategies, or to wire trading into your own infrastructure, it's all there. That's a rabbit hole for another article, but it's worth knowing the ceiling is high.

Why bother with an exchange at all? Because the liquidity is here.

This is the actual point of the whole exercise, and it's where the earlier pieces click together.

The reason I started with Arweave is that it's exactly the kind of token that's *annoying* to get any other way. The same goes for GLMR (Moonbeam) — a token that, for most Canadians, otherwise means wrestling with a DEX, a bridge, and a wallet you're praying you configured correctly. Let me unpack why that "other way" is so painful, because the contrast is the whole sales pitch.

To buy GLMR on a decentralized exchange, you'd typically need to: acquire a more common token first, move it to a compatible wallet, bridge it across chains (hoping the bridge isn't the

week's exploit headline), connect that wallet to a DEX you've vetted yourself, and then accept whatever slippage a thin liquidity pool hands you. That's five steps, each with its own failure mode, and the slippage alone can quietly cost you 3-4% on a small order. Now compare: both [AR](#) and [GLMR](#) are listed and tradeable on [Kraken](#) as spot assets — **including CAD-denominated pairs**. You go straight from Canadian dollars to [Arweave](#) or [Moonbeam](#) in a single trade, with deep liquidity behind the price so you're not eating that slippage tax. The exchange collapses a five-step DeFi odyssey into one tap. And — closing the loop with the earlier section — once you own it, you can withdraw that [AR](#) or [GLMR](#) to your own wallet paying only the network fee.

Step back and the pattern is clear: [Kraken](#) lists several hundred assets against seven fiat currencies, CAD among them. The list runs well beyond [AR](#) and [GLMR](#) — a DeFi-native token like [Injective \(INJ\)](#), for instance, is another of those assets that feels like a scavenger hunt anywhere else but sits a single tap away here. For a Canadian who wants exposure to the harder-to-find corners of the market without becoming a part-time bridge-security researcher, that breadth is the product. You're paying a small, transparent fee to outsource a genuinely hard problem.

There's one genuinely important catch, though, and I'd be doing you a disservice to bury it. Canadian regulators impose a **net purchase limit of \$30,000 CAD over any rolling 12-month period** on most altcoins for retail clients. [Bitcoin](#), [Ethereum](#), [Bitcoin Cash](#), and [Litecoin](#) are exempt; [AR](#), [GLMR](#), [INJ](#), and friends are not. Residents of Alberta, BC, Manitoba, Quebec, and Saskatchewan are exempt from the cap, and accredited or eligible investors get higher ceilings. On a \$200 experiment this is purely academic — but if you're planning to deploy serious capital into altcoins, know the ceiling exists before you sprint at it.

About that sign-up bonus (my experience, with the honest fine print)

Here's where I have to switch registers — from "verified fact" to "this is what happened to me" — because the two genuinely deserve different levels of confidence, and a good teacher flags the difference rather than blurring it.

When I signed up through the invite link and entered the referral code — and pay attention here, because *this is the step people miss*: the code is required even when you arrive through an invite link — then funded and traded **\$200 or more**, I received **\$45 in [Bitcoin](#)** as a welcome bonus. The way the promotion was structured, the referrer and I could *each* earn up to **\$350** through the program.

So here is the exact recipe that worked for me. Open the link, enter the code when prompted, fund with at least \$200, place a qualifying trade — and the BTC showed up:

Link: <https://invite.kraken.com/JDNW/7uuhqx1c>

Code (tap to copy):

2twtq8yj

Now the honesty, because the internet is full of crypto "bonuses" that evaporate on contact, and you should develop a healthy reflex about all of them. Promotional terms vary by region, by time, and by the specific offer live when you sign up. Some Kraken promotions aren't available to Canadian users at all, depending on the regulatory weather that quarter. What I'm reporting is *my* outcome under the terms that applied to *me* on the day I signed up — the \$45 BTC, the code above, the \$200 trade minimum, the up-to-\$350 structure — not a guarantee that you'll see the identical offer. The right mental habit is to treat any advertised bonus as a pleasant maybe, verify the actual terms attached to the *current* promotion before you count on it, and never let the bonus be the reason you're here.

If the offer that greets you matches what greeted me, wonderful — that's \$45 of BTC you didn't have to buy. If it doesn't, you've still onboarded for free, traded for ~1%, and gotten clean CAD access to liquidity that would otherwise cost you a weekend and a bridge exploit's worth of anxiety. The bonus is the cherry; the sundae underneath is worth eating on its own.

The full receipt

Let me lay the whole experiment on the table, start to finish, so you can see every number in one place:

I started with \$200 CAD, a CIBC account, a driver's license, and a smartphone. I signed up via the invite link **plus the referral code** (remember, the code is needed even with the link). Verification took minutes, using only the ID and the phone camera. Funding by Interac e-Transfer cost **\$0 in fees** — the full \$200 landed. On the crypto side, Kraken adds **no fee** on most crypto deposits and no markup on withdrawals, so you pay only the blockchain network fee to move coins out. The trade itself — \$200 into Arweave via the basic app, no subscription — left me holding **~\$194 of AR** after the ~1% and spread. My sign-up bonus was **\$45 in BTC**, via the code below plus a \$200 trade, inside an up-to-\$350 structure for both parties (my experience; terms vary — verify the live offer). Had I used Kraken Pro instead of the basic app, I'd have paid roughly 0.25–0.40%

instead of 1%. And the catch to keep in mind: the \$30,000 CAD per-12-month altcoin cap applies to most retail Canadians, and nothing here is CIPF-insured.

The headline number — \$200 in, \$194 of a hard-to-find token out, with zero onboarding fee and no exchange-imposed exit fee — is the part I can prove from Kraken's own published fees. The bonus is the cherry, and cherries are seasonal.

If you've been standing at the edge of this pool waiting for a clean way in, this is roughly as clean as Canadian crypto onboarding gets right now. A license, a phone, a free e-Transfer, and you're holding the token you actually wanted.

Start here

Everything above leads to one simple action, so here it is with nothing in the way. Open the link, enter the code, verify with your license, fund \$200 by e-Transfer, and make your first trade:

Sign-up link: <https://invite.kraken.com/JDNW/7uuhqx1c>

Referral code (tap to copy) — required to qualify for the up-to-\$350 bonus:

2tw tq8yj

And while you're deciding what to buy first, the live prices are one click away: [Bitcoin](#), [Ethereum](#), [Arweave](#), [Moonbeam \(GLMR\)](#), and [Injective \(INJ\)](#).

This is a personal field report and reflects fees, limits, and promotions verified as of June 2026. Fee schedules and promotional terms change frequently — confirm current details on Kraken's official pages before you fund or trade. Nothing here is financial advice. Crypto is volatile; only deploy what you can afford to lose. The Kraken links in this article are affiliate links, which means the author may earn a referral reward if you sign up through them — at no extra cost to you.